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ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Laura Gentile, a Hampden County clerk, checked a ceiling for mold at the decaying Roderick C. Ireland Courthouse.

For a new courthouse, an eye-popping price

Springfield roiled by \$2b cost and state's choice of location, builder

By Catherine Carlock
and Samantha J. Gross

GLOBE STAFF

SPRINGFIELD — The building where Laura Gentile has worked for three decades is, in a word, toxic. Black stains streak the concrete. Remnants of mold speckle ceiling tiles. Many who work there have been diagnosed with cancer; some have died of ALS.

Indeed, the Roderick C. Ireland Courthouse is in such decay that the state is planning to spend \$2 billion to replace it. Yes, that's billion with a "b."

That jaw-dropping sum has cast a shadow over the Western Massachusetts city, which has long resented the power Beacon Hill wields and the attitude some feel it holds toward the farther reaches of the state.

Massachusetts leaders, however, argue

that \$2 billion — which includes both the cost of construction and rent over at least 40 years — may prove less expensive than some alternatives.

But everyone from Gentile and her colleagues in the Hampden County courthouse, to the mayor of Springfield, to the unhappy losing bidders, is railing against the state's location for the courthouse and team they chose to build it — which includes a Northern Virginia firm specializing in government facilities and a pair of politically connected Boston developers.

Among the questions swirling about the project is the price tag. Because how on Earth could what essentially looks like a six-story office building on a barren block in Springfield cost \$2 billion?

To be clear, the construction itself costs

much less: an estimated \$462 million, according to the winning proposal, and perhaps as much as \$525 million, state officials said.

Those expenses will be rolled into the lease payments, which over a 40-year period will top \$1.6 billion; the remaining are the typical costs to operate the building over that extended timeframe, said Hannah Carrillo, a spokesperson for the Division of Capital Asset Management and Maintenance, or DCAMM, the state agency overseeing the procurement.

Construction costs have soared across the US since the COVID-19 pandemic, with disruptions to the global supply chain, spikes in materials costs, inflation, tariffs, and wars in Ukraine and Iran.

COURTHOUSE, Page A7

Despite vows, some cross casino picket line

Encore's strong lure makes it tough to measure strike's effects on the business

By Karyna Cheung
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

After a recent dinner with a friend, Malden resident Mark Crehan was in a bind. His friend wanted to go gambling at Encore Boston Harbor — the Everett casino where 1,300 workers have now been on strike for more than a month.

Crehan, a member of the electricians union IBEW Local 103, refused at first. He comes from a union family — he says his father was a Teamster — and he wasn't about to cross the picket line. He'd even driven by the picketers in recent weeks and honked his horn in support.

But as the night went on, his friend kept pressing. Once a regular at the casino, Crehan said he finally gave in. They spent a few hours at Encore, and Crehan walked out with \$500 less in his pocket.

"I never thought I would cross a picket line," Crehan said. He also hadn't realized the Local 25 Teamsters were among those on strike in Everett. He insists he won't go back until the contract dispute is over.

But not everyone is willing to give up their source of entertainment to support the workers. A month into the strike, it's not yet known how much of a dent it's made on Encore's business. Revenue reports and foot traffic numbers have not yet been released by the casino or the Massachusetts Gaming Commission.

On a recent weeknight, dozens of striking workers chanting and beating drums could be

ENCORE, Page A10

From the ocean to an appointment

Many Bermudians come to Boston for health care

By Allyson Chiu
GLOBE STAFF

When Darren Glasford needed a PET scan in 2024, the Bermuda resident did what many of his neighbors in the British territory often do for higher-level health care: He skipped the local hospital and hopped on a plane to Boston.

While Bermuda did not have the PET scans that Glasford needed for treatment of his prostate cancer, his 1,500-mile round trip was hardly extraordinary. For decades, residents of the tiny islands in the Atlantic Ocean have come to Boston as part of a little-known pipeline for medical care.

Such trips are so routine that more than 90 percent of the population had some level of insurance coverage for overseas health services.

"Boston has a big reputation with Bermuda," said Glasford, 56, a police officer whose government insurance covered much of his treatment-related costs, including travel. "Direct flight there, direct flight back, and they have the expertise, so it just makes sense."

The health care connection between Bermuda and Boston came into focus last week after a medi-

BERMUDA, Page A7

Fighting addiction with compassion, not judgment



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

"They wanted me to get clean, but they weren't forcing me," said Daniel Wood, a recovering opioid user.

Police initiative grows by offering help right away

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

KINGSTON — The young man is a known drug user, and police have come looking for him again. Three attempts, two addresses, and he continues to elude them.

Still, they try. In an unmarked SUV, Sergeant Ryan Calter and Victoria Butler, a civilian, arrive unannounced outside the modest house where he is believed to be staying.

But there will be no arrest here this day; Calter and Butler aren't even assuming he's done something wrong. Instead, they're here to offer help following a recent overdose. To listen without judgment. And to connect him with services that will steer him toward recovery.

"We've all kind of been there. We've all stumbled," said Butler, executive di-

rector of Plymouth County Outreach, which connects with the area's vulnerable residents. "There are a lot of people who are too ashamed to make the call."

What happened in Kingston is but one example of a decade-old approach to drug addiction and recovery, rooted in Massachusetts, one that stresses compassion over handcuffs. Pioneered by police chiefs in Gloucester and Arlington, and backed by an ambitious nonprofit organization, it has spread since then to hundreds of police departments across the nation.

While the epidemic of opioid use and fatal overdoses has eased, it hasn't gone away. So, the nonprofit Police Assisted Addiction and Recovery Initiative, or PAARI, is as relevant as ever, focused on treating substance abuse more as a medical condition rather

ADDICTION, Page A10

A SOLEMN ANNIVERSARY IN THE MIDEAST

Three years after the Hamas-led attack on the site of the Nova Music Festival in Reim plunged the region into war, Israelis mourned Wednesday (at right, an installation in Tel Aviv). Militants killed 200 people and took 251 hostage. Israel's retaliatory offensive killed tens of thousands of Palestinians, destroyed much of Gaza, and drove most of its 2 million residents from their homes. Most are still living in squalid tent camps. **A3.**



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The woman Tennessee tried and failed to execute, Christa Pike, was "angry and confused" after she woke up, her lawyer said. Meanwhile, a Texas court denied a request to stay the scheduled lethal injection of a man. **A2.**

In their first debate, Governor Maura Healey and Republican challenger Mike Minogue will have to contend with rising costs and President Trump, while Senator Susan Collins of Maine and Democratic opponent Troy Jackson had few standout moments in their face-off. **B1.**

Amazon will sublease 375,000 square feet of office space in the Seaport, in a partial exit that may reflect an uneven market recovery from the pandemic. **D1.**



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